

CJ 540



THE BASICS OF SOCIAL RESEARCH

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How do we know if/why something exists?

- Is it cold on the dark side of the moon?
- Does racism exist?
- Does protest influence political change?

QUESTION



METHODOLOGY

Science of finding out if something exists

OBSERVATION



EXPLANATION

Empirical Scientific Inquiry

Observations

Direct:

You conduct observations of society

Indirect:

Others conduct observations of society

Explanations

You develop reasons, a theory, an explanation for the patterns you see in the observations

Statements about if/why something exists must be both empirical and logical

**EMPIRICAL
OBSERVATIONS**

*verifiable through actual
measurements, data, observations*

**LOGICAL
EXPLANATIONS
(FOR OBSERVATIONS)**

*makes logical sense, or is based on
prior theories*

EXAMPLE

"it is cold on the dark side of the moon"

EMPIRICAL OBSERVATION

*actual measurements confirm the
assertion/claim/expectation*

LOGICAL EXPLANATION

*it makes sense, since the sun isn't
shining on that side*



EMPIRICAL SCIENTIFIC INQUIRY

Isn't concerned with or doesn't rely on:

- Speculation
- Moral judgment
- Subjective preference
- Debates of value



Why do we need empirical scientific inquiry?

problems with

NON-EMPIRICAL, HUMAN INQUIRY

- Lacks reasoning about cause & effect
- Inaccurate/mistaken observations
- Overgeneralizations
- Illogical reasoning



EMPIRICAL SOCIAL SCIENCE

*research methodology for
understanding the social
world*

*the scientific study of
society*



OBJECTIVITY IN EMPIRICAL SOCIAL SCIENCE

- *Certain topics cannot be “antiseptically objective”*
- *Science achieves objectivity through intersubjectivity.*

Social scientists examine relationships between variables, across many observations, and develop explanations for these relationships

OBSERVATION



EXPLANATION

OBSERVATIONS

(AKA) UNITS OF ANALYSIS

the level of social life under investigation

Individual Level

- People

Aggregate Level

- Family
 - Organization
 - City, County, or State
-

*every observation under
investigation has many variables*

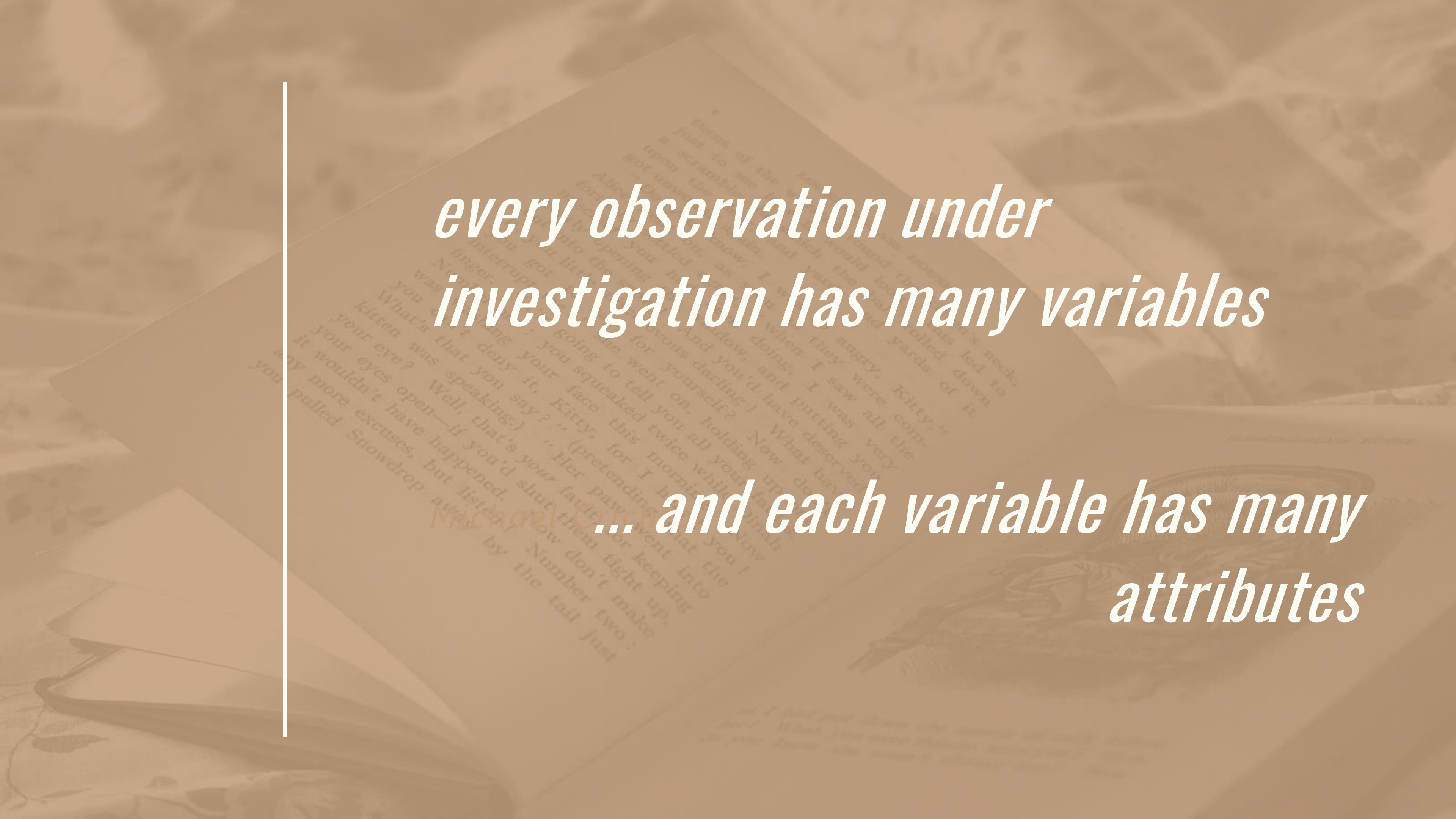
Michael Crichton

VARIABLES

Properties of observations that are different (vary) across observations.

- Social class
- Age
- Gender
- Sex
- Race

can also differ within one observation, over time



*every observation under
investigation has many variables*

*and each variable has many
attributes*

Michael Crichton

VARIABLES

properties (groupings of characteristics) of observations, can be broken into attributes

- **RACE/ETHNICITY**

ATTRIBUTES

specific characteristics or qualities that describe each observation, can be grouped into variables

- **BLACK, WHITE, LATINX, ETC.**

VARIABLES & ATTRIBUTES

Some Common Social Concepts

Young Social class Race/ethnicity
Occupation Upper class Gender
African American Political views
Liberal Age Plumber Female



Variable

Attributes

Age

Young, middle-aged, old

Gender

Female, male

Occupation

Plumber, lawyer,
data-entry clerk . . .

Race/ethnicity

African American, Asian,
Caucasian, Latino . . .

Social class

Upper, middle, lower . . .

Political views

Liberal, conservative



VARIABLE TYPES

DEPENDENT & INDEPENDENT VARIABLES

Dependent

- The variable to be explained
- The “effect”
- The “Y” variable
- The outcome

Independent

- The variable expected to account for/explain the dependent variable
- The presumed “cause”
- The “X” variable
- The predictor

DEPENDENT & INDEPENDENT VARIABLES

Dependent

The object of research. The thing you're trying to explain

Independent

The thing that influences the dependent variable

How do these differ?

The independent variable is often seen as influencing the dependent variable



Social scientists examine relationships between variables, across many observations, and develop explanations for these relationships

RELATIONSHIPS BETWEEN VARIABLES



OR



Social scientists examine **relationships between variables**, across many observations, and develop explanations for these relationships...

... by relying on theory and hypotheses

OBSERVATION



EXPLANATION

EXPLANATION

SOCIAL THEORY

Systematic explanations for the observations we see in society

- Statement about why two or more variables (X and Y) are related
- Based on prior literature

Sex (X) is related to earnings (Y), because...

Types of Social Theory

- **INDUCTIVE**

Theoretical argument developed from findings/observations. Then moves to literature

- **DEDUCTIVE**

Theoretical argument based on premises/hypotheses derived from prior research, without findings/observations. Moves next to observations.

EXPLANATION

HYPOTHESIS *Specific statements about attributes within variables & their relationship*

- Testable statements about relationship between specific attributes within the two (or more) variables
- Based on prior literature

Directional: Women (X category) earn less (Y category) than men

Non-Directional: Men and women (X categories) have different levels of earning (Y)

THEORY

Abortion attitudes are related to religiosity because of exposure to sermons about the "sanctity of life" in churches

HYPOTHESIS

People who attend church regularly are more likely to oppose abortion than people who do not attend church regularly

FUNCTIONS AND TYPES OF SOCIAL RESEARCH

The purposes and ways of conducting empirical social science

FUNCTIONS OF SOCIAL RESEARCH

Exploratory Research

Mapping out a topic for further study

- Googling or reading about a group/topic

Descriptive Research

Describes data collected

- Exec reports on crime in cities, marijuana opinions

Explanatory Research

Explains **why** a social phenomenon occurs, uses data

- Journal articles, uses data & theory



TYPES OF SOCIAL RESEARCH

Primary (Obtrusive)

Observations

Interviews

Ethnography

Participant
Observation

Experiments

Surveys

Focus
Groups

Case
Study

Secondary (Unobtrusive)

Observations

Secondary
Data Analysis

Content/Text
Analysis

Case Study
(Historical)

Types of Data (Observations)

- **QUALITATIVE DATA**

non-numerical data (e.g. text, conversations, correspondence)

- **QUANTITATIVE DATA**

numerical data (e.g. numbers used to represent some social phenomenon)

TYPES OF SOCIAL RESEARCH

Analysis of Qualitative Data

Interviews

Ethnography

Participant
Observation

Focus
Groups

Content/Text
Analysis

Case
Study

Analysis of Quantitative Data

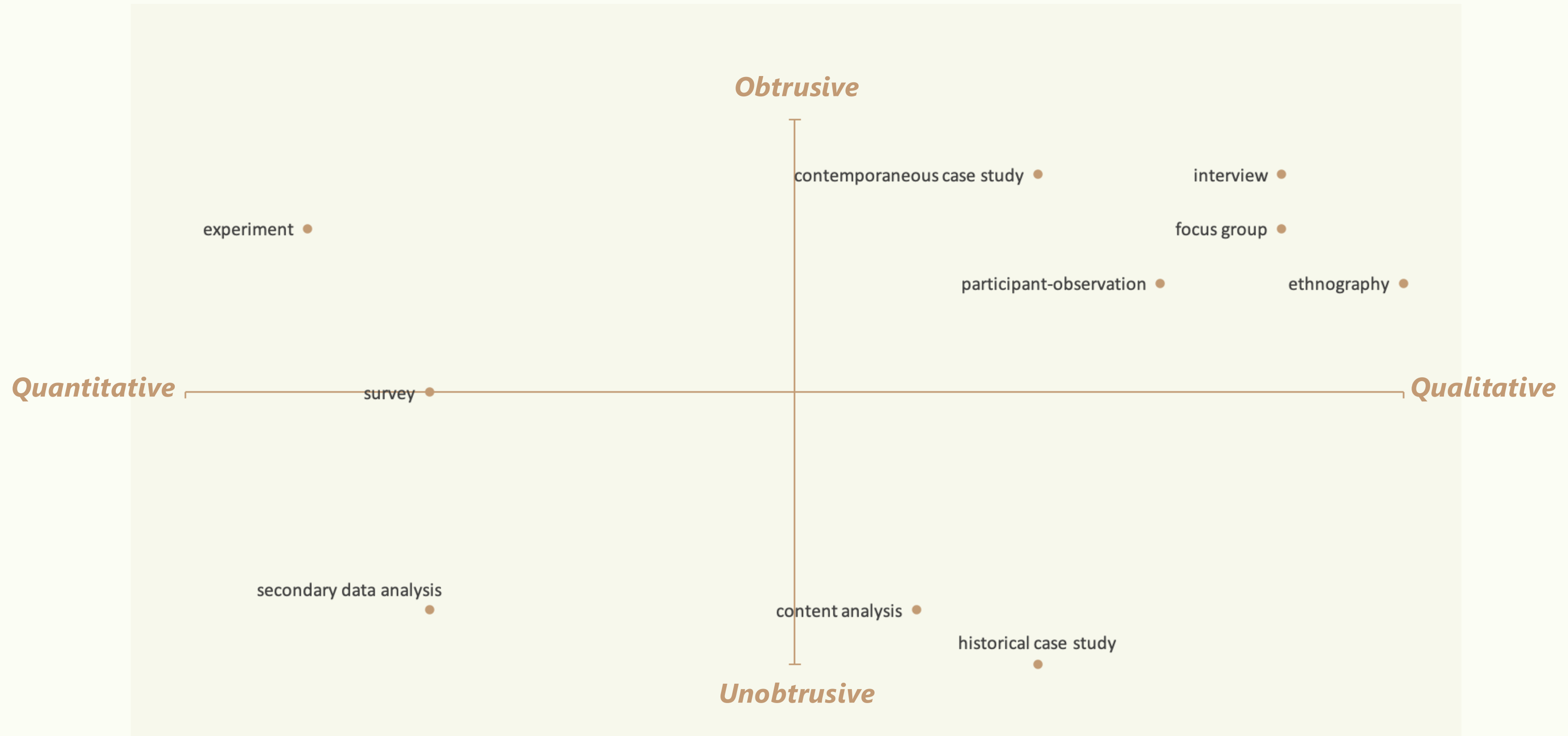
Experiments

Secondary
Data Analysis

Content/Text
Analysis

Surveys

BREAKDOWN OF TYPES OF SOCIAL RESEARCH



Types of Analysis

- **QUALITATIVE ANALYSIS**

search for meanings, search for patterns, themes, experiences, beliefs, attitudes amongst text data

- **QUANTITATIVE ANALYSIS**

search for statistical associations between numerically-measured variables